XIII—Bring Me My Flute!

> ‘And so those who were before in favour now fell out of favour, and those who were before out of favour came into favour, those who had been near became afar, and those who had been afar became near. Praise be to Him! who ruleth absolutely in his kingdom as it pleaseth Him. And the common people with as little sense as brute beasts repeated continually nothing but “Allah Akbar.”’
>
> – Abdul Qadir Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh*

At the end of November 1581, Akbar returned to Fatehpur in triumph. His ‘great officers [and] loyal servants’ lined both sides of the road for several kilometres out of the city, as their emperor rode in upon a ‘heaven-like’ elephant, heralded by drums and musicians, accompanied by his sons and his amirs. His people, too, had come out in crowds for a glimpse of their glorious monarch, and were ‘gathered in astonishment on the roofs and at the doors’. There was even a rebel called Bahadur, from Bengal, awaiting Akbar’s arrival. He was brought out ‘with chains on his neck, and stocks on his feet’, and executed.[1]

The Bengal rebellion wasn’t over; it would simmer for a long while yet. Its originators, the Qaqshals, would only return to the imperial fold in the spring of 1584, some two years from now;[2] and disturbances in the east would continue until the very end of Akbar’s reign. To the west, too, there would be outbreaks of unrest in Gujarat, both from discontented mansabdars and a Gujarati prince, Muzaffar Shah, the suppression of whose stubborn ambition earned Abdur Rahim the title of khan-khanan.[3]

There would be another kind of rebellion against Akbar’s empire, more scattered but as sustained as the resistance in Bengal or Gujarat. ‘By one count,’ writes Michael Fisher, ‘there were 144 armed revolts by landholders during Akbar’s reign that were large enough to be recorded by his central administration; additionally, lesser conflicts were frequent, particularly after each harvest.’[4] One of these landholders, Abdullah ‘Dulha’ Bhatti, remains a folk hero in Punjab. It was not just his warlords, then, who were unhappy at losing their independent, unaccounted wealth, the zamindars of Hindustan – ‘warrior-aristocrats’ as Fisher describes them – were equally